

STAGE FIFTEEN • BUSINESS & ORGANIZATIONAL ACUMEN

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Fifteen • Business & Organizational Acumen

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Fifteen is analytically demanding, and participants with less workplace experience may feel genuinely behind at points. Part 3 leans on this specifically — several situations address how to keep less-experienced participants genuinely engaged rather than sidelined.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck or discouraged.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Fifteen. Everything else in this program — your skills, your leadership, your projects — happens inside an organization. Today we start with genuinely understanding that organization, not just your own corner of it.”

“This stage works best with real material. If you have a current job, internship, or even strong familiarity with a company from the outside, keep it in mind throughout today — every exercise gets noticeably more useful applied to something real.”

Opening Session 2

“Last time was about understanding the organization as it exists. Today we move to analysis — stakeholders, processes, problems, and building a genuine business case.”

“This is our longest, most demanding session. FIRST S14, building a full business case, deserves real time — we won't rush it to protect the schedule.”

Opening Session 3 (Stage Close)

“Our final session is about synthesis — connecting daily activities to strategy, seeing problems from a genuinely different vantage point, and reflecting honestly on this whole stage.”

“We'll close today by looking back across all twenty-five FIRSTS, not just this session's six. Keep Sessions 1 and 2 in mind as we go.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST S1 → S2

"You can now explain how your organization creates and captures value. Let's zoom out to the structure around that value creation — who's actually involved, and how."

FIRST S6 → S7

"You now understand how budgets get created and approved. Let's put that alongside revenue and costs in the one document that shows the full financial picture: the P&L."

Session 1 → Session 2

"You now understand how your organization works. Today we put that understanding to work — analyzing real stakeholders, real processes, and real problems."

FIRST S13 → S14

"You've found a genuine root cause. A business case is where that analysis turns into something a real decision-maker could actually act on."

FIRST S16 → S17

"You've made a clear, evidence-backed recommendation internally. Now let's check that recommendation against something outside your own organization: the actual market."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You can now analyze a real business problem end to end. Our final session zooms out further still — connecting daily work to strategy, and reflecting on this practice as a whole."

FIRST S22 → S23

"You've just investigated why a real decision was made. Let's turn that same investigative instinct toward something you can actually change yourself: a real process inefficiency."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

A participant has limited work experience to draw on

“School, a part-time job, even a club or team you're part of all count as organizations. The dynamics — unclear goals, a broken process, a confusing decision — show up almost everywhere, not just in a corporate job.”

Someone's business case (S14) stays vague on numbers

“Even a rough estimate is more useful than no number at all. What's your best genuine guess, and what would you need to know to make it more precise?”

A participant struggles with the Executive Perspective Exercise (S21)

“Try naming one thing a decision-maker two levels above you would actually be worried about here — budget, risk, or how this affects other teams. Start with just one.”

Someone's competitive or market research (S17–S18) relies on outdated impressions

“When's the last time you actually verified that? A quick search now might tell us whether that's still true.”

A participant is reluctant to name a genuine, uncomfortable gap during S25

“The honest gaps are usually more useful to name than the comfortable strengths — no one's going to think less of you for naming financial literacy, or anything else, as still a work in progress.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, discouraged, or feel behind — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST S7

Profit & Loss Awareness

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants will genuinely never have looked at a real P&L before. Normalize this explicitly rather than assuming familiarity — have a simple, annotated sample ready as a backup for anyone without organizational access to a real one.

FIRST S14

Business Case Created

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is the most demanding single exercise in the stage and can trigger real frustration if participants feel rushed. Protect its time deliberately; if the session is running behind, trim a later, lower-stakes FIRST instead of compressing this one.

FIRST S21

Executive Perspective Exercise

FACILITATOR NOTE

Genuinely difficult for many participants, especially those without much exposure to leadership decision-making. That difficulty is expected and useful — reassure participants who find this hard that struggling with it is normal, not a sign they're behind.

FIRST S25

Business Acumen Reflection

FACILITATOR NOTE

As the full-stage close, this can feel like a test or a grade if framed poorly. Explicitly reframe it as an honest inventory, not an evaluation — naming a real gap here should feel safe, not like an admission of failure.